

The Third Edit: Prepare for the Rat-mageddon

An **asteroid** with a 1.3 per cent chance of hitting Earth in 2032. Sci-fi fears of an AI **apocalypse**. But for the real **menace** of these times, check under the sofa. Rats — lots and lots of rats. **Think The Birds, not Armageddon**. A group of researchers have used public rat sighting and inspection data from 16 cities — mostly in the US, but also including Toronto, Amsterdam and Tokyo — over a period of between seven and 17 years to see how the numbers had changed. The result: 11 of those cities saw significant increases in the rat population.

Human population density and loss of **vegetation correlated** positively with multiplying **rodents**. More food waste and more holes to **scurry into** make for a happy and healthy rat population. But the strongest **correlation** was found with rising temperatures amid global warming, an issue that's **exacerbated** in cities due to the **urban heat island effect**. When it's warmer, rats have lower **mortality**, can stay above ground and **forage** for longer, and are more **fertile**. The collective **noun** for these **pesky** home **invaders** is a "**mischief**" of rats, and what mischief they can **wreak**, from carrying diseases to **contaminating** food and damaging **infrastructure**. That's not to mention, as the study says, the mental **toll** it **takes on** the people who have to **put up with** them.



But don't reach for the rat poison just yet. For one thing, the study found that trying to **get rid of** rats that are already there is much less effective than methods of making cities less **hospitable** to them. What is needed is modern waste management practices, building regulations, and more resources for public education and **surveillance**. There's a **host of** things that can and should be done at the municipal level, including in India; although there's no data from the country, the same conditions apply. **In the meantime, hunker down**, rodent-proof your houses and prepare for **Ratmageddon**. **Not with a bang but with a squeak.**

[Practice Exercise]

- Red/blue coloring of words in the sentence indicates subject verb relationship; where 'red' denotes 'subject' and 'blue' denotes 'verb'.

Vocabulary

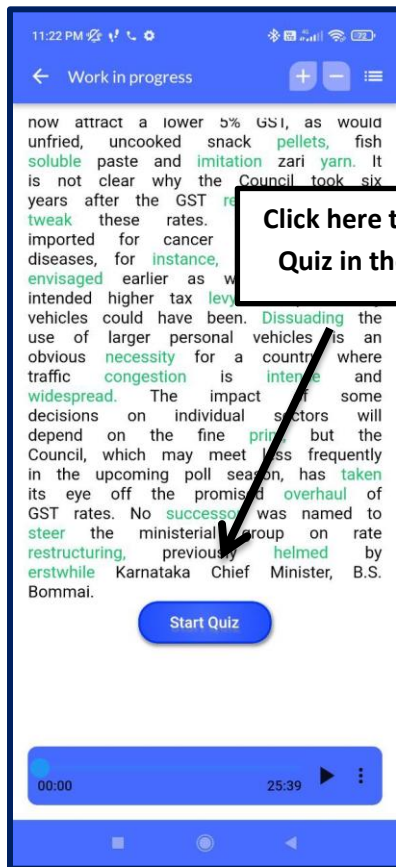
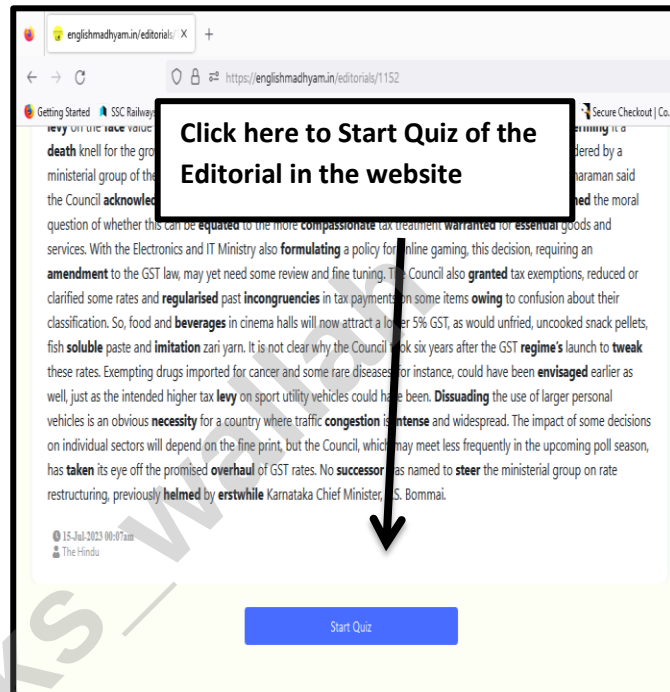
1. **Asteroid** (noun) – Space rock, celestial body, meteoroid, small planet, cosmic stone उल्का पिंड
2. **Apocalypse** (noun) – Catastrophe, disaster, doomsday, destruction, end of the world प्रलय
3. **Menace** (noun) – Threat, danger, hazard, risk, nuisance खतरा
4. **Think The Birds, not Armageddon** (phrase) – Imagine a widespread but less dramatic problem, referring to a slow-building crisis rather than a sudden catastrophe महाविनाश की बजाय धीरे-धीरे बढ़ती समस्या की कल्पना करें
5. **Vegetation** (noun) – Plants, greenery, flora, foliage, plant life वनस्पति
6. **Correlate** (verb) – Relate, connect, associate, link, correspond आपस में जोड़ना
7. **Rodent** (noun) – Small mammal, rat, mouse, squirrel, beaver चूहे, गिलहरी आदि छोटे दंतधारी जानवर
8. **Scurry** (into) (verb) – Rush, hurry, scamper, dash, scramble तेजी से दौड़ना
9. **Make for** (phrasal verb) – Lead to, contribute to, result in, cause, create कारण बनना
10. **Correlation** (noun) – Connection, relationship, association, interrelation, linkage सहसंबंध
11. **Exacerbate** (verb) – Worsen, aggravate, intensify, heighten, escalate बढ़ाना
12. **Urban heat island effect** (noun) – A phenomenon where cities become significantly warmer than surrounding rural areas due to human activities जहाँ शहर ग्रामीण क्षेत्रों की तुलना में अधिक गर्म हो जाते हैं
13. **Mortality** (noun) – Death rate, fatality, perishability, human lifespan, end of life मृत्यु दर
14. **Forage** (noun) – Search for food, hunt, scavenge, food-seeking behaviour भोजन की तलाश
15. **Fertile** (adjective) – Productive, reproductive, rich in growth, abundant in reproduction उपजाऊ
16. **Pesky** (adjective) – Annoying, troublesome, irritating, bothersome, unwelcome परेशान करने वाला,
17. **Invader** (noun) – Intruder, trespasser, infiltrator, attacker, unwanted guest घुसपैठिया

18. **Mischief** (noun) – Trouble, naughtiness, wrongdoing, prank, misbehaviour शरारत
19. **Wreak** (verb) – Cause, inflict, bring about, unleash, impose कारण बनना
20. **Contaminate** (verb) – Pollute, infect, taint, spoil, defile प्रदूषित करना
21. **Infrastructure** (noun) – Basic facilities, framework, foundation, system, public utilities बुनियादी ढांचा
22. **Take a toll on** (phrase) – Negatively impact, cause harm, affect badly, damage बुरा प्रभाव डालना
23. **Put up with** (phrase) – Tolerate, endure, bear, accept, cope with सहन करना, झेलना
24. **Get rid of** (phrase) – Remove, eliminate, dispose of, eradicate, exterminate से छुटकारा पाना
25. **Hospitable** (adjective) – Welcoming, accommodating, friendly, conducive अनुकूल
26. **Surveillance** (noun) – Monitoring, observation, watch, oversight, supervision निगरानी
27. **A host of** (phrase) – A large number of, a great deal of, numerous, plenty of बहुत सारे
28. **In the meantime** (phrase) – Meanwhile, during this time, in the interim, for now इसी बीच
29. **Hunker down** (noun) – Take shelter, settle in, prepare for a challenge, stay put कठिन परिस्थिति के लिए तैयार होना
30. **Rat-mageddon** (noun) – A humorous reference to a potential rat infestation crisis, combining "rats" and "Armageddon" चूहों से होने वाली आपदा, चूहों का महाविनाश
31. **Not with a bang but with a squeak** (phrase) – Referring to a situation that ends in an anticlimactic, insignificant, or less dramatic manner than expected धमाके के साथ नहीं, बल्कि मामूली हलचल के साथ समाप्त होना

Summary of the Editorial

1. Scientists have identified a growing menace—rats—based on public sighting and inspection data from 16 cities across the US, Toronto, Amsterdam, and Tokyo.
2. Over a period of 7 to 17 years, 11 of these cities recorded significant increases in their rat populations.
3. The primary factors linked to rising rat numbers include human population density and loss of vegetation.
4. Increased food waste and availability of hiding spaces further support the rapid growth of rat populations.
5. The strongest correlation, however, is with rising temperatures due to global warming, especially in cities with the urban heat island effect.
6. Warmer temperatures result in lower rat mortality, extended foraging periods, and higher fertility rates.
7. Rats cause multiple problems, from spreading diseases and contaminating food to damaging infrastructure.
8. The psychological burden on humans living with increased rat infestations is also a significant concern.
9. The study suggests that simply using rat poison or extermination methods is ineffective in controlling the population.
10. Instead, making cities less hospitable to rats through better urban planning is a more effective solution.
11. Improved waste management practices are crucial in controlling rat populations.
12. Stricter building regulations can help reduce hiding spots and entry points for rats.
13. Increased public awareness, education, and surveillance can play a key role in mitigation efforts.
14. Though there is no specific data from India, similar conditions make it likely that the rat problem exists there as well.
15. The editorial humorously warns of an impending "Rat-mageddon" and advises people to rodent-proof their homes rather than panic.

Practice Exercise: SSC Pattern Based

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